

THE PUP ROUTINE

THE CALM, CHECKABLE ROUTINE

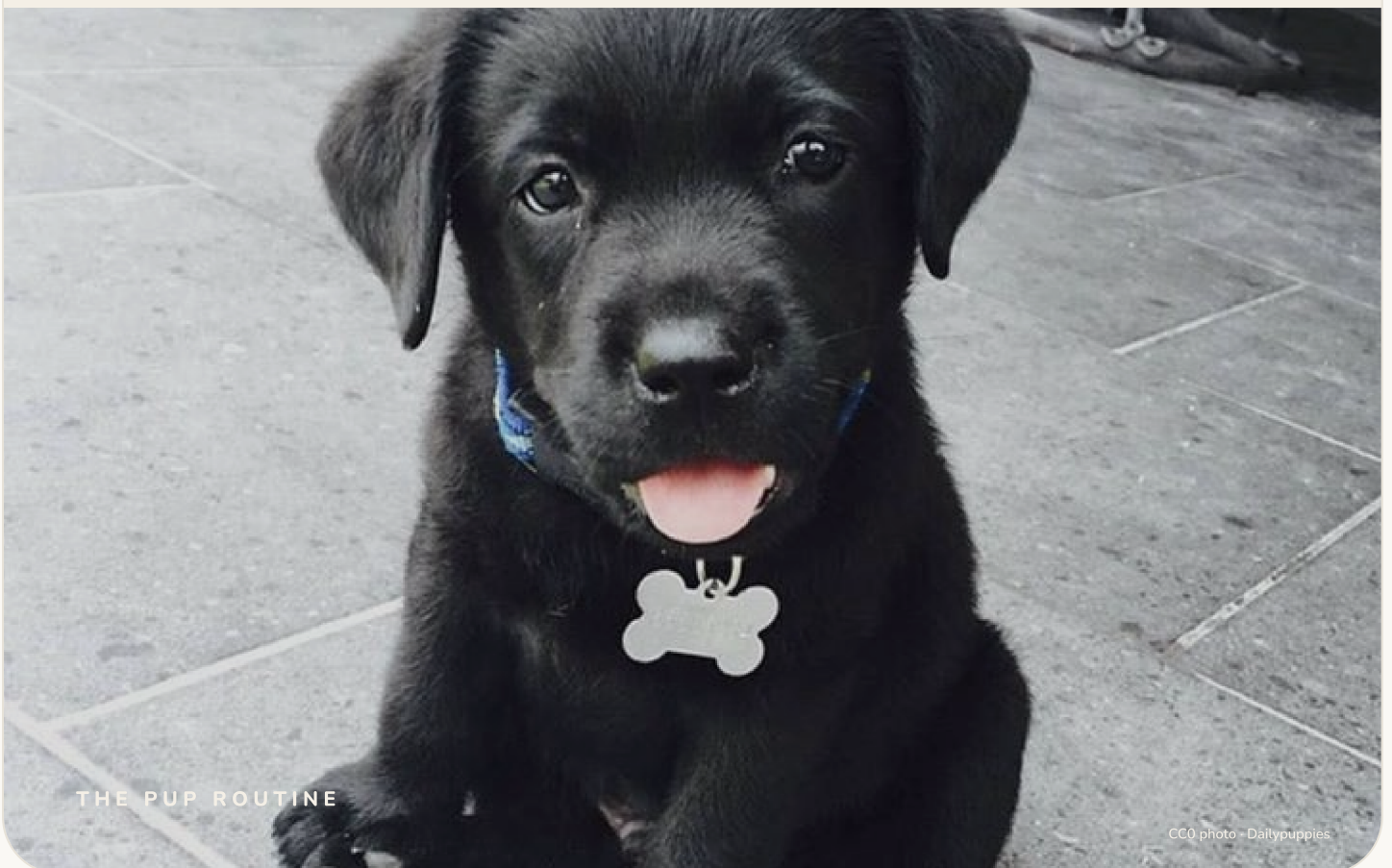
The First 8 Weeks Puppy System

Potty, crate, sleep, socialization and vet visits — laid out so you always know what today is for.

8-WEEK ROADMAP

5 SYSTEMS

PRINTABLE TRACKER



THE PUP ROUTINE

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How this system works

Puppies don't need a perfect owner. They need a **consistent** one. This guide gives you five small systems that run your first eight weeks: a daily routine, a potty schedule, a crate plan, a sleep rhythm, and a socialization checklist.

Print it, put it where the household sees it, and let the routine do the thinking while you enjoy the puppy.

- ☐ **Follow the routine, not your mood.**
Dogs learn from repetition; the schedule is the trainer.
- ☐ **One rule per moment.**
Each section below is a checkable action, not theory.
- ☐ **Everyone runs the same system.**
Inconsistency is the #1 reason training stalls.

This guide describes widely used training and husbandry conventions (positive-reinforcement methods, AAHA-style vaccination timing). It is not veterinary advice — confirm health decisions, vaccine timing and anything about your specific puppy with your own vet.

THE WEEK-BY-WEEK FOCUS · AGE ~8–16 WEEKS

Week	Main focus	Win of the week
1	Settling in · potty rhythm · crate = good place	Puppy naps in crate with door open
2	Potty schedule tightens · name response · handling (paws, ears, mouth)	First full day without an indoor accident
3	Crate door closed for naps · short alone-time reps (1–5 min)	Calm 5 minutes alone
4	Socialization push (see checklist) · sit & recall foundations	10 new experiences logged
5	Leash intro in quiet places · impulse-control games	Loose-leash 20 meters
6	Alone-time stretches (15–30 min) · settle-on-mat	Relaxed 30 minutes alone
7	Generalize: new places, surfaces, sounds · recall outdoors on long line	Recall past a mild distraction
8	Consolidate. Keep every system running; raise difficulty slowly	The routine feels boring — that's success

The daily routine

Young puppies thrive on a predictable loop: **sleep → potty → food/water → play/train → potty → sleep**.

Repeat that loop all day and most "behavior problems" never appear.

07:00 Wake + potty Carry out if needed. Same door, same spot, every time.	07:15 Breakfast + water Potty again 10–20 min after eating.
07:45 Play / 3-minute training rep Short. End before the puppy tires.	08:30 Crate nap · 60–120 min Puppies need 18–20 h sleep/day.
10:30 Potty → play/socialization One new experience per day is plenty.	12:00 Lunch → potty → nap Same loop.
15:00 Potty → enrichment Sniffing, chew, puzzle. Mental work tires more than running.	17:30 Dinner → potty → family time Calm presence, handling practice.
19:30 Last play + training rep Wind down after this.	21:30 Final potty → crate Boring, calm, lights out.

Adjust the clock, keep the loop. Your hours can differ — what matters is the same order of blocks every day, and a potty break after every sleep, meal, drink and play burst.

AFTER SLEEP Potty first	AFTER FOOD Potty again	AFTER PLAY Potty again
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Potty & crate training

SYSTEM 2 · THE THREE RULES

1

Out after every trigger.

Waking, eating, drinking, play, excitement — and at least every hour at 8–10 weeks. A common rule of thumb: hold time in hours $\approx$ age in months + 1, awake.

2

Boring trips, big parties.

Go out on leash, stand still, say nothing. The moment the puppy goes: praise + a treat on the spot outside, never after coming back in.

3

Interrupt, never punish.

Catch an accident mid-act: calm "ah-ah", scoop up, finish outside, party. Found it later? Clean it with enzymatic cleaner and say nothing.

Accidents are data. Every accident = the schedule was too loose or supervision slipped. Tighten the interval for two days, then widen again.

The crate is a bedroom, not a punishment. Build value in steps and never move two steps at once.

SYSTEM 3 · THE CRATE LADDER

1

Crate open, meals + treats scattered inside

Move on when...

Puppy walks in freely

2

Feed in crate, close door during the meal, open after

Move on when...

Relaxed through the meal

3

Door closed for naps while you're in the room

Move on when...

Falls asleep without fuss

4

You leave the room for 1–5 min during a nap

Move on when...

Stays settled

5

Stretch alone-time: 15 → 30 → 60 min, random order

Move on when...

Calm at 60 min

CRATE SIZE

Stand up, turn around, lie flat — not bigger during potty training.

WHINING TEST

A settling puppy quiets in ~2 min; frantic escalation means you moved too fast. Go back one step.

AT NIGHT

Crate near your bed the first weeks; one silent night potty trip at 8–10 weeks is normal.

Sleep & socialization

18–20

HOURS SLEEP PER DAY

An overtired puppy looks like a "bad" puppy: biting, zoomies, ignoring everything.

When behavior falls apart, the answer is almost always a nap.

RHYTHM

1 hour awake → 1–2 hours asleep, all day, at 8–12 weeks.

PROTECT NAPS

Family rule: sleeping puppy is invisible.

WITCHING HOUR

Calm chew in the crate, lights low.

SYSTEM 5 · SOCIALIZATION CHECKLIST

Roughly before the 14–16 week mark, puppies file new experiences as "normal". After it, new things default to "suspicious". One new thing a day, always paired with treats, always at the puppy's pace.

Before the vaccine series is complete, socialize **smart**: carry the puppy in public, use the car as a viewing platform, visit vaccinated friendly dogs at home — avoid ground contact in high-dog-traffic areas. Behavior professionals broadly agree the socialization window matters too much to wait out entirely; agree on the line with your vet.

People & handling

- ☐ Men with beards/hats · children · elderly
- ☐ Bikes, joggers, strollers passing
- ☐ Paws, ears, mouth, tail handled daily
- ☐ Collar grab → treat (10× per week)
- ☐ Brush, towel rub, nail clipper shown
- ☐ Being picked up calmly

Places & surfaces

- ☐ Car rides (short, ending somewhere fun)
- ☐ Pavement, grass, gravel, metal grate, wet ground
- ☐ Stairs (few steps), elevator, automatic doors
- ☐ Quiet street → busier street progression
- ☐ Vet practice happy-visit (scale + treats, no needle)

Dogs & animals

- ☐ Calm adult dog (vaccinated, known)
- ☐ Watching dogs play from a distance
- ☐ Cats / livestock seen calmly

Sounds & sights

- ☐ Vacuum, doorbell, washing machine
- ☐ Traffic, thunder/fireworks audio at LOW volume
- ☐ Umbrellas, hi-vis vests, wheelchairs, skateboards

Vet & vaccine convention

Timing follows widely used veterinary guidelines (e.g. AAHA canine vaccination guidance); exact schedule, products and local legal requirements are your vet's call.

Age	Standard step
6–8 weeks	First core combination vaccine (distemper/parvo series) · deworming · vet intake check
10–12 weeks	Second core vaccine · discuss microchip registration, parasite prevention
14–16 weeks	Final core vaccine of the puppy series · rabies where required by local law
~6 months	Discuss neutering timing with your vet (breed- and size-dependent)

KEEP IT VISIBLE

Print the tracker.

Put it where the household sees it, and let the routine do the thinking while you enjoy the puppy.

HEALTH DECISIONS

Your vet has the final call.

Exact schedule, products and local legal requirements are your vet's call.

YOUR QUESTIONS FOR THE VET

The daily tracker

Put this page where the whole household sees it. Accidents become data; the routine stays consistent.

Time	Potty (✓ / accident)	Meals	Nap start-end	Training / new experience
Morning				
Midday				
Afternoon				
Evening				
Night				

WEEK REVIEW · SUNDAY, 5 MINUTES

☐ Accidents this week vs last week — fewer?

☐ Longest calm alone-time this week: _____ min

☐ New experiences logged: _____ / 7

☐ Is everyone in the house running the same rules?

☐ Next week's single focus: _____

After week 8

The systems stay, the difficulty rises: adolescence, recall around distractions, enrichment routines, alone-time for real workdays.

That's what the weekly Pup Routine email walks you through — one system per week, no fluff.

NEXT

Adolescence

NEXT

Recall around distractions

NEXT

Enrichment routines

NEXT

Alone-time for real workdays

WHAT IMPROVED

WHAT STILL NEEDS WORK

THE PUP ROUTINE

**One system per week.
No fluff.**

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